

ZHIYUAN LAI

Undergraduate Researcher at Peking University

Research interests: information practices, marginalized communities, digital inequality, and human-centered AI

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EDUCATION

Peking University, Beijing, China

B.Mgt. in Information Management and Information Systems

Sep 2023 – Jun 2027 (expected)

B.A. in Sociology (Double Major)

Sep 2025 – Jun 2027 (expected)

GPA: 3.72/4.00; Rank: 7/82

National Tsing Hua University, Taiwan

Visiting Student

Jun 2025 – Aug 2025

Conducted a study on Taiwanese attitudes toward generative AI under the supervision of Prof. Tzu-Hua Wang.

PUBLICATIONS & MANUSCRIPTS

Manuscripts under review

Tang, Y., & **Lai, Z.** (Under Review) Empowering LGBTQIA+ identity formation in China through LLM-based chatbots. *Journal of Information Science*.

Lai, Z., Liang, X., Jiang, C., & Li, Z. (Under Review) Lives of the infamous: Identity linkage potential and everyday information practices among people living with HIV. *ACM/IEEE-CS Joint Conference on Digital Libraries (JCDL)*.

Peer-reviewed publications

Lai, Z., & Tang, Y. (2026). Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use. *Information Research: An International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 328–344.
<https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64121>.

Chen, N., **Lai, Z.**, Liu, Y., Li, J., Wang, R., & Yan, P. (2026). See, trust, and interact: How AI disclosure shapes high school students' trust. *Information Research: An International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 1099–1145.
<https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64165>.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE & SELECTED PROJECTS

34th Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition

Nov 2025 – Mar 2026

Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among People Living with HIV — Information Practices as a Survival Strategy

Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Conducted multi-site fieldwork at Beijing Ditan Hospital and the Beijing Red Ribbon Home, combining semi-structured in-depth interviews, participant observation, and online ethnography.
- Developed an analytical framework explaining how people living with HIV regulate information exposure, navigate identity-linking information flows, and translate information into sustainable everyday action.
- Received Third Prize; presented at the 2026 Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association.

33rd Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition

Nov 2024 – Mar 2025

Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms

Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Led a mixed-methods project combining ethnographic fieldwork in rural Hebei Province with computational social science methods.
- Independently scraped and analyzed public comment data from Douyin and Kuaishou using Python and BERTopic to model user interaction and self-presentation.
- Authored the final report, which framed short-video use as a flexible resistance to social marginalization and a tool for community building.

- Received First Prize; presented at the 2025 Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association.

Undergraduate Research Program, Leader	May 2024 – Oct 2025
<i>Public Trust and Attitudes toward Generative AI in China</i>	Advisor: Dr. Pu Yan
(Selected as an Excellent Undergraduate Research Project)	

- Led a multi-stage, mixed-methods study and developed and validated a GenAI Trust Scale for the Chinese public across two survey studies.
- Designed and executed a controlled experiment incorporating eye tracking to determine the impact of different AI disclosure strategies on user trust.
- Analyzed eye-tracking and survey data using R, finding that simple AI labels enhanced trust in conversational contexts but decreased trust in news consumption.

AI & Society Research Group, Research Assistant	May 2024 – Present
Advisor: Dr. Pu Yan	
- Conduct literature reviews and quantitative data analysis for the National Natural Science Foundation project “<i>A Study on the Influencing Factors and Mechanisms of the Algorithmic Divide.</i>” - Support the Beijing Social Science Foundation project “<i>A Study on Algorithm Literacy among Beijing Citizens</i>” by refining survey designs and analyzing data.	

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2026	Xi'an, China Jul 2026
Poster Presentation: “Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among People Living with HIV.”	
19th National Doctoral Forum in Library and Information Science	Beijing, China May 2026
Research Presentation: “The Lives of the Infamous: Information Practices as a Survival Strategy for People with HIV.”	
iConference 2026	Edinburgh, Scotland, UK Mar 2026
Full Paper Presentation: “Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use.”	
Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2025	Chengdu, China Jul 2025
Full Paper Presentation: “Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms.”	

TEACHING & MENTORING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, AI Literacy Educational Outreach Program, Fucheng Aidi High School, Shandong	Jul 2026
First-Year Peer Advisor for the 2025 and 2026 Incoming Cohorts	Aug 2025 – Present

HONORS & AWARDS

2024 – 2025	Merit Student; National Encouragement Scholarship; Second-Class Peking University Scholarship
2023 – 2024	Award for Academic Excellence; National Encouragement Scholarship

RESEARCH METHODS & TECHNICAL SKILLS

Qualitative Research	Interviews, participant observation, online ethnography, NVivo
Survey & Experimental Research	Survey design, scale development, eye tracking, R, Stata, SPSS
Computational Methods	Web scraping, BERTopic, Python, SQL
Web Technologies	JavaScript, HTML, CSS
Languages	English (TOEFL iBT: 104), Chinese (native), Hakka (native)